On hand jobs, AWP, the internet, truck drivers and embodied living

This Week in Shakes (more Hundreds)

[27 May 2024]: "Using the Word as Bait" — blind bisexual goose; green porno; slippery texts; sloshy belly of texts; eggs; love as curiosity + quantum mechanics; heresy + agitation; erotic consumption

by Jackie Wang

by Lauren Berlant

by Kameelah Janan Rasheed

INDEX

bios 5

On hand jobs, AWP, the internet, truck drivers and embodied living by Jackie Wang 7 - 11

This Week in Shakes by Lauren Berlant 12 - 14

[27 May 2024]: "Using the Word as Bait" — blind bisexual goose; green porno; slippery texts; sloshy belly of texts; eggs; love as curiosity + quantum mechanics; heresy + agitation; erotic consumption by Kameelah Janan Rasheed 15 - 28

HTMLGIANT— an online literature blog founded by American author Blake Butler. It presents itself as a "literature blog that isn't always about literature", and includes book reviews and interviews. It is considered to be an important outlet for alternative literature (Alt Lit), a loosely defined literary movement.

Supervalent Thought— Lauren Berlant's research blog, tracking academic and random engagements with two scenes and concepts: ordinary life and attachment/detachment. They want to know why people stay attached to lives that don't work. This is a political and a personal question. Psychoanalysis meets affect theory and Marxist critical theory.

Lauren Berlant— George M. Pullman Distinguished Service Professor of English at the University of Chicago. They explored how modes of social membership flourish and preserve critical and optimistic attachments to the political as a site of collective ongoingness or potentiality. Author of The Anatomy of National Fantasy (1991); The Female Complaint: The Unfinished Business of Sentimentality in American Culture (2009); and The Queen of America Goes to Washington City: Essays on Sex and Citizenship (1997) and Cruel Optimism (2011). As well as edited volumes Intimacy (2000); Our Monica, Ourselves: Clinton and the Affairs of State (with Lisa Duggan 2001); and Compassion: the Culture and Politics of an Emotion (2004).

Jackie Wang— a poet, library rat, trauma monster, harpist, and Assistant Professor of American Studies and Ethnicity at University of Southern California. She is the author of The Sunflower Cast a Spell to Save Us from the Void, Carceral Capitalism, as well as the chapbooks Tiny Spelunker of the Oneiro-Womb and The Twitter Hive Mind Is Dreaming. When not writing poetry she researches race, surveillance technology, and the political economy of prisons and police. Her tumblr blog remains acitve since 2009 and can be found under the following URL: https://loneberry.tumblr.com/

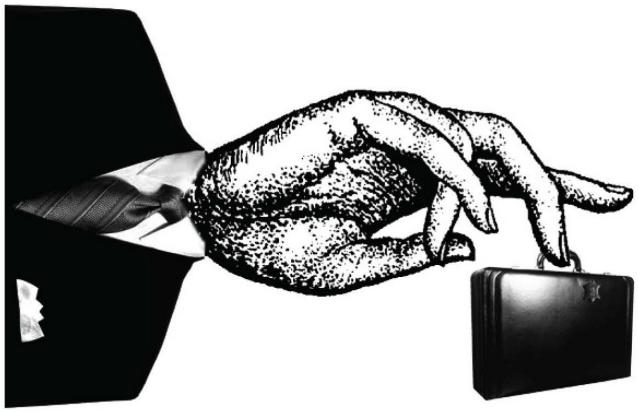
Kameelah Janan Rasheed— a learner born in East Palo Alto, CA, currently based between Brooklyn, Berlin and Johannesburg. She explores writing practices across all species, states of living, states of consciousness, and substrates. She teaches at Yale University, School of Art (Sculpture) and independently through guest teachings and workshops. In 2020 she founded Orange Tangent Study - a consulting business supporting cultural producers in designing materials, experiences, and systems for expansive learning. She runs a substack newsletter called I Will (?) Figure This All Out Later: https://newsletter.kameelahr.com/

February 13th, 2011 / 8:29 pm

Behind the Scenes & Craft Notes & Events & Random

J Wang

On hand jobs, AWP, the internet, truck drivers, and embodied living



Maybe before sleep I was thinking, "I haven't thought about that kid I used to stalk in a while." And then I had a dream about him. He was being cruel to me and then I started to retreat and he sensed me leaving, maybe not physically going away but mentally withdrawing…he could feel it. He started acting kindly toward me, like his cruelty was just a cover for the deep sense of tenderness that was his true feeling. I started to run. I don't know why. I slid beneath tables that were randomly placed in an art museum like a nightmarish obstacle course. I got up and kept running. He was chasing me. He just wanted to be kind. And yes, I wanted that closeness but could not bear it. I don't know why. I woke up and went to the bathroom and thought about how most of my life I've lived for other people. As in, obsession. As in, all thoughts orbiting around the chosen one(s)…a flash-flood of understanding in the holy shitter then ZAP!—it's gone. While watching a film I zone out for a split second and am hit by the sensation of intimacy, the kind that exists between two people but it's not attached to any real people; it's just a bodily memory of what it feels like. You're usually so used to your body; you walk around and sometimes hardly even notice it's there, feeling it even less while you browse the internet. But when you're getting to know someone it suddenly becomes this very new thing. And all at once you're so in your skin, totally delirious beneath the possibility of touch. When I first met my current partner I was instantly obsessed

and I hated myself for it. I thought, you cannot be trusted in the company of people. You have all these insane feelings and nobody else is with you in them. That makes you feel like a real maniac. There's no reason for any of it. Maybe I'm a maniac but mostly I'm a grandma. In high school one of my friend groups de-friended me because they thought I was "too intense." I am drawn to people who seem singular in an unconscious way…weirdoes, recluses, awkward nerds. Never showy or confident people or people that carry themselves well.

Why the fuck am I writing this. After AWP both Ariana Reines and Kate Zambreno blogged about how they do it for the young girls, how the young girls respond and feel comforted. They put themselves out there unapologetically and I like that, but I also think about how I could never be that, how I was never a libertine in that way but perhaps very much so in others, how I never sought The Fuck (unless it was with myself), regardless of whether it was a casual pleasure fuck or a complicated hate fuck. I spent my adolescence obsessively trying to avoid all contact with boys/men and fantasizing about stabbing the ones that sexually harassed me. In middle school I was horrified to find that someone wrote down in a slam book that I had been fucked in the ass by some kid named Jordan, which was a fucking lie. I was a loner nerd but then all the cool girls befriended me because I had a hot gangsta older brother. They would sleep over my house as a way to hook up with other boys in the neighborhood. Late at night the girls would call the boys and negotiate sex plans. Once Katie arranged for me to give a hand job to some kid even though I didn't want to. Behind some park late at night I definitely did not want to touch it. Later his friend tried to get a hand job from me, noting my "soft, tiny hands." I kept saying noooo and, "I can't give you a hand job because my best friend likes you and I would never do that to her." A year and a half ago, when I was hitchhiking/bicycling alone around the east coast one summer, I got a ride from a trucker who told me he was driving straight to Philly. But it turned out he wasn't even going to Philly, and he also wasn't planning on heading straight there. He stopped somewhere to sleep and I was stuck in the truck with him. He begged me for hand jobs like that jerk from middle school. I said noooo and he kept begging and then he started offering me money while saying, "Come on! Loosen the fuck up. Don't you want to make money for your trip? It's not like I'm asking you to fuck me or anything." To shut him up I said, "I have a boyfriend" because I didn't know how he would react if I said, "I'm a lesbian."

(I'm going to let you in on a little secret: little girls often make out and touch each other. My first lesbian experience was when I was 5 or so, and we said we were just "practicing" for Mr. Right.)

Miraculously, the boyfriend lie worked on the horny truck driver. My fake boyfriend saved me. It was while hitchhiking that I learned that the truckers

call sex workers that hang around the truck stops "lot lizards." The nice old man truck driver who gave me a ride before I got stuck with the horny guy got on the radio to try to find me a ride and everyone on the radio immediately started chiming in, "Why do her tits look like? Does she have a nice ass?" He said, "She ain't no lot lizard. Just trying to find a ride to Philly." The old man gave me a knife and bought me a subway sandwich before I got in the truck with the horny guy. After I got out of the horny guy's truck, the next guy that gave me a ride was very Philly-Italiano in a tender kind of way. I put my bicycle in the back of his truck and started to climb into the front seat, but as soon as I got into his truck a woman in a nursing uniform drove in front of the truck, pointed her finger at me and screamed for me to get out of the truck. She told me to get inside her car and when I was in the passenger seat she said, "I saw you on the side of the road with your sign. You can't get in that man's car!" The guy got out of the truck and said, "What's going on here? Has this young girl escaped from the mental hospital?" I wondered, do I really look like an escaped mental patient? The woman was a zealous Jehovah's Witness who forced religious pamphlets onto me before I got out of her car. The crazy lady was comforted when the Italiano Philly guy told her, "Don't worry ma'am. I'm a God-fearing man myself." (Cue up the tough guy proudly holding up his crucifix.) This is not writing about literature but maybe it can pass as literature. Here's one connection: all good writing happens in movement. So. We go. This will certainly have many typos. I was going to post this on my personal blog but realized that I can't because my aunts stalk me on there. Amy McDaniel has been posting about food so I figure I must have a little room to wiggle in words. Amy doesn't know who I am but I saw her read and talk at the college I recently graduated from and I thought she was amazing and felt angry when the boys were taking up too much space and she didn't get to talk as much. I think this might have been when Alec brought Blake Butler and Justin Taylor. But now that I think of it, I think Blake came at a separate time. I think Blake might have actually been to the house I lived at in Sarasota during a multimedia performance/reading event I organized. But I think he might not have actually gone into the house…which is okay because I would have just felt embarrassed. This was before I even knew what HTMLGIANT was. Well, I had heard of it, but I didn't start digging into the internet until I graduated and quit my two jobs. Isn't it funny that "jobs" comes after "hand" in the phrase "hand jobs"? Imagine your hand wearing a nice suit and carrying a briefcase as it walks off to work while you look at it tenderly and think, "My hand is off to its job again." If I had a nickel for every time a gross guy told me to touch his penis…. After a while you start to really hate being a woman, especially one with big tits. Once I was sleeping over a friend's house and a Christian boy crawled into the bed I was sleeping in and said, "Touch my shaft. Come on. Touch my shaft." I said, "What are you doing? I'm dating your best friend." Then he started freaking out while saying, "How am I going to remain abstinent until marriage???"

There was once a time in my life when I'd sit down to write every day and every time I would go to the place I refer to as THE ZONE. My point is, writing used to be something that just happened, not something I would do. As in, it did to me. I've always been a rather passive person and this worked out for us.

I am in Glasgow, Scotland right now. I came here two days after AWP. It took me nearly two days straight of constant travel to get here because I was trying to do it cheap. I scammed my way to NYC via bus and got stuck in traffic for two hours and ran to the subway and train and airport with a Belgian girl who was also on the bus from Bmore to NYC and, incidentally, was trying to catch the same flight to London. I thought everything would be different as soon as I left—that I would GET IT BACK. Maybe things are different but I don't even realize it? Today I went to a building called the Center for Contemporary Arts to try to read and write while sitting at one of the tables in the center of the arts complex. They promptly kicked me out because I didn't buy any food and for the rest of the day I was fuming while thinking about how all space is capitalist space, how much I hate the culture of contemporary art, how it is impossible to even sit down or gather with friends or do anything at all unless you are engaging in some sort of economic exchange. Maybe the sidewalk is the last of the spatial commons but if you stopped walking or sat down while on a sidewalk, you'd be "obstructing traffic," and that certainly is not allowed. My point is, every time I sit down to write, I go a little insane. I abort everything I start writing lately because I don't give a shit about what I have to say, because I want to be less of a person (the least you can possibly be while still being technically alive); to resist the urge to say, to be seen, to individualize, to be distinct. If I start to disappear from the internet it's because I feel like I cannot morally justify writing, being an Author-Artist, or dumping all of my energy into THE WORD. Because anything having to do with my "self" literally pains me. Did you go to AWP? Did you feel connected or alone in your head? How did it feel to be near the people you know digitally, to know them embodied for a few days? I actually found it hard to make eye contact with people because I felt embarrassed and gross inside my skin. I hope I didn't come across as rude. I was very excited to see everyone but I was nervous and extremely sleep-deprived. I met many of the HTMLGIANTers, bought tampons with Ariana Reines, made a fool of myself in front of Bhanu Kapil and Eileen Myles (especially Bhanu, after giving her an ambien letter and bundle of drawings), hung at a bar with M. Kitchell and Kate Zambreno, wandered the DC streets for hours lost and alone while it rained, was berated by a possibly homeless eastern European man who made racist remarks about me, stayed up all night talking to an old classmate about Clarice Lispector, flipped out when I found out Clarice Lispector loved Spinoza (!!), hung with Alec and other Florida people…and so on. Tim Jones-Yelvington was definitely the best dressed. I think it was Mike Young who asked me at lunch if I live in a punk house and I said I

live in a "Marxist Goth Cult," which may or may not be a joke. I will leave it to the imagination. A few months ago I deleted my facebook and it definitely feels like I exist less to the world. I've been reading too much post-marxist theory and feeling paranoid about subjective/immaterial production under postmodern capitalism—Empire, you might call it—and have been thinking about how facebook/tumblr/twitter/WEB 2.0 operates according to a consumerist logic, the constant production-consumption feedback loop that exploits our human NEED for acknowledgment while turning our fears and longings and sadness into tiny poops to be consumed without actually granting us the satisfaction of interpersonal connection that we often desperately crave. That, to me, is the saddest thing…the way an email only feels good for a few minutes, the way we are immediately waiting for the next thing, searching for something deeper while our sense of self worth gets bound up with the amount of hits or "likes" we receive. I'm not indicting anyone. I crave such contact as much as anyone else but this just doesn't feel right. I am very fucking afraid.

Tags: alienation, AWP, hand jobs, people, THE INTERNET

Wang, J. (2024, October 26). On hand jobs, AWP, the internet, truck drivers, and embodied living. HTMLGIANT. https://htmlgiant.com/random/on-hand-jobs-awp-the-internet-truck-drivers-and-embodied-living/

THIS WEEK IN SHAKES (MORE HUNDREDS)
June 9, 2014, 9:31 pm
Filed under: affect, Affect Theory, ambivalence, Attachment, class, Craziness, food, Love, Mood, non-sovereignty, psychoanalysis, queerness, sexuality, supervalent_thought, Theory of this Blog, writing |
Tags: experiment, food, intimacy, poetry, sentimentality, the _body, writing

My friend Martha Howard asked me to post my experiment with shakes. I might post others. There's a lot of variety among them, as you can already see from the last few posts.
*****

Monday

The protein drink is a chalky substance diluted and well-enough flavored that a small store sample persuades you that you would drink it at home–only to find at home that, no matter how much attention you'd paid at the time, you can't get the makeup to look as good or the hair to fall again the way it did at the original moment of optimism. I had committed to two tubs of vegan breakfast powder. One recalled the fleck of inhaled bugs and the other a bully pushing my face down thoroughly into tough wet dirt.

When it comes to experiments I commit my mouth. Five months of unquenchably pasty tongue prison ran out finally and I leaped to acquire seven new shake packs full of promise and percentages. Today: Vega One all-in-one nutritional shake in French Vanilla: 50% of daily intake vitamins & minerals, 15 grams of protein, 6 grams of fiber & 1.5 grams of omega 3, plus antioxidants, probiotics and greens. Dairy, gluten & soy free, no sugar added, and 135 calories. Complete daily essentials to help you thrive. Good for your body and the planet: clean . . . without compromise. The ampersand's shortcut efficiency figures negativity baroquely.

My shake was green. The world has not enough water for everyone, nor amounts sufficient to dilute this shake so that its flavor could be rejoined at the party after the chaos of getting in, finding the room with the coats, and moving outside for a quick smoke. Vanilla is a tart baby when you drink it from the bottle and a teasing allusion if you bite the bark. Vanilla is also the sex you slide into, the pleasant-event of that hand again there, or the feeling of feet arching. My tongue sought out but never landed.

Tuesday

The dread of another virtue-breakfast was nuked today by politics, a painful turn of need and interest towards hypervigilance. There was a Punch and Judy Show with all the thrill and erotic boredom of your average sexual antagonism. Punch called Judy a vampire, and then Judy threw her feminism hard, knocking his need to eat the brains he also finds repulsive. The mob of tweeting lurkers verged with stakes for theory's heart.

Disgust and love keep me very quiet. The chocolate version of yesterday's foul mud was eleven additional calories, which will today be soundly punished for my own good.

Wednesday

Last night was spent battling the cat's episodic loneliness and so this exhausted morning's Vega Energizing Smoothie was an especially dreadful prospect, reminding me that the verb "to stomach" shows that bodies have not only their own ideas but radically private sovereign tongues. Vanilla Almondilla offers as its main gift what it doesn't have: dairy, gluten & soy free, no sugar added. In the Coke Zero era the ideal contribution of a food is its subtraction of dark consequences from pleasure. 90 calories, 10 grams of protein. Xanthan gum is the aspartame of the health shake, which is also green.

Thursday

The iPad reads aloud in the kitchen this morning while I pull things together. Voice Dream offers a woman's halting, nasal phonetic literalism to relay a scholarly book on comedy, preferring spectacle's excesses to narrative's enchainments. My naked partner enters the white room holding the ginger cat. He wonders, is it the Russian model of narrative where y is the effect of x or the Aristotelian one of intensities, reversals, and consequences? Raw Protein Beyond Organic Protein Formula features Bob Marley Brand coffee: it is free of gluten, dairy, soy, fillers, artificial flavors, and good ones. I can't stop laughing.

Friday

I spent the last night alone and so the morning was like a hotel morning with its shapeless offer of waking without obligation to be a particular way. The noise of a mind open to a limited formlessness makes breathing and blinking worth nothing in particular, and I considered taking a break from breakfast altogether because of the quiet. But the night's move through finitude required some pause after I lifted my head up and laughed at how turtle that everyday stretching is. I say to myself get ahold of yourself. The Vega Energizing Tropical Smoothie was wonderful, a wonder.

Saturday

I'm well-acquainted with the genre of the Skype dinner date with old lovers.

After recipe hunting left me numb, today's shake was my dinner protein, Vega Reparative in Berry–a revoltingly sweet attempt at Nestle's Quick Strawberry. I reenacted to my love a scene from Domestic Violence of an old white woman telling stories on her husband, a college professor who had so abused her that she saw an angel flying round her room looking down kindly from the high white ceiling to offer advice. "I know I'm crazy," she says softly, with her rice-paper skin like mica, pixillated, awry.

Sunday

The woman with Parkinson's swims everyday and each day seems to diminish a little, which I sense because she always wears the same pants, of a slightly burnt orange hue. Bending stretches things out, so don't presuppose, I tell myself, knowing that in the future a snapshot of this naked gym tableau might well portray a secret no-one could have known. We used to talk about her bad back, which we now have nostalgia for. She laughs at my Amazing Meals shake, with its grainy and delicious austerity. I dash it down as though it matters that it gets somewhere.

Berlant, L. (2024, October 26). This week in Shakes (more Hundreds). Supervalent Thought. https://supervalentthought.wordpress.com/2014/06/09/this-week-in-shakes-some-more-hundreds/

[27 May 2024]: "Using the Word as Bait" — blind bisexual goose; green porno; slippery texts; sloshy belly of texts; eggs; love as curiosity + quantum mechanics; heresy + agitation; erotic consumption

blind bisexual goose; green porno; slippery texts; sloshy belly of texts; eggs; love as curiosity + quantum mechanics; heresy + agitation; erotic consumption

KAMEELAH JANAN RASHEED
MAY 27, 2024

بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

Bismillah. We begin everything with the name of Allah. We say Bismillah to initiate an act to acknowledge the intention and the ethics we carry with all that follows Bismillah.

> So writing is the method of using the word as bait: the word fishing for whatever is not word. When this non-word—between the lines—takes the bait, something has been written. Once whatever is between the lines is caught, the word can be tossed away in relief. But that's where the analogy ends: the non-word, taking the bait, incorporates it. So what saves you is writing absentmindedly.

Lispector, Clarice. Água Viva. United States: New Directions, 2012.

This is part of the newsletter's "Using the Word as Bait" (Clarice Lispector) strand.

Writing Conditions

$$34^{\circ}\ NE,\ 89\ feet\ Elevation$$

$$26\ May - 27\ May\ 2024\ (08:18pm - 02:17am; 10:45am - 1:52pm)$$

$$5mg\ of\ Melatonin\ +\ Ashwagandha\ Tea$$

ɔ Coming Home/ *Blind Bisexual Goose, Penelope the Platypus, Green Porno, and Buffy*

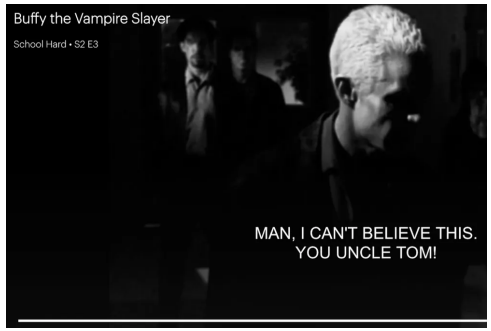
I am writing to you, and I am writing to myself. Hello!

I got home from a week of travel—from Los Angeles to San Diego to Providence—and have slept from Friday night until this exact moment I am sitting to write this newsletter. I am not documenting much on these trips; just trying to be present without the pressure of "evidence" or content. Upon opening Instagram for my allotted social media displeasure, I was pleased to come across a 2018 New Zealand story about the death of Thomas, a blind bisexual goose in a love triangle. At this point, I think we are all aware of my not-so-casual interest in the complex lives of our non-human homies. Y'all may remember my ongoing obsession with Penelope the Platypus, the interspecies feminist hero who, after being stolen from her homeland and then forced to make babies with some dude named Cedric, faked her pregnancy and escaped the Bronx zoo in the mid-1950s, never to be seen again. I am drawn to these stories because they remind us of our complex world, and the complexity challenges humans not to see ourselves as the main character.

In another timeline, I am a biologist who writes books and makes illustrations about the interior lives of non-human animals. Speaking of which, I came across Isabella Rossellini's Green Porno series on Criterion. As Criterion describes it, "With brightly colored costumes and paper puppets, Rossellini acts out a panoply of reproductive oddities [...] Part nature documentary, part DIY cartoon." This truly is my jam!

I love weird stuff like this and one day, I will make my absurdist film (I have already written a synopsis). I have just the right about of delusional time perception to create a science curriculum using these films as an anchor.

I am managing to carve out more space for myself. I am rewatching Buffy the Vampire Slayer for no reason but to get to the episode where Spike calls Angel an Uncle Tom — yes, you read that correctly.

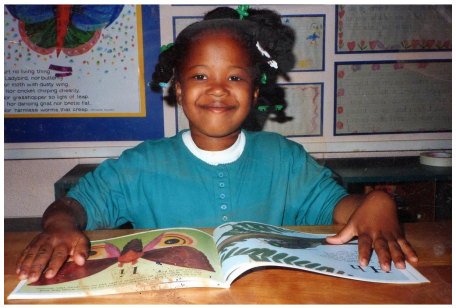


I blame Buffy and a host of other 90s high school shows for convincing me that high school would be a series of supernatural battles and cool hangouts to see artists like Rasputina performing Transylvanian Concubine at the Bronze!? I also watched Private Life with Paul Giamatti and Kathryn Hahn. It tells the story of a couple somewhat obsessed with fertility and the lengths they are willing to go to have their own child. I liked the film, but also like Paul Giamatti and Kathryn Hahn so it was not too much of a sell.

```
My watching assignment for this week:
1. Poor Things
2. Dogtooth
3. Plan 75
```

I am excited about some of my long flights to Norway and France this summer so I can have some extended time to watch high above the ground. This week, of course, is Yorgos Lanthimos heavy! I think I am leaning into things that are death related as I ramp up for death doula training. By the way, this is not an easy process. After researching and getting into a program, I realized that I do want to go for an advanced certificate in thanatology. No one could have told me a year ago that I would be going back to school to study death.

ɔ How to Read / *Slippery Texts, Some, Lispector, Wilk, Stein, Love as Curiosity, and Heresy*

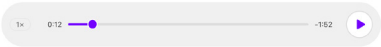


I am trying to find my way back to fiction, starting with Organ Meats by K-Ming Chang.

```
My reading assingments for this week:
1. Finish Organ Meats (K-Ming Chang)
2. High Static, Dead Lines: Sonic Spectres & the Object Hereafter
(Kristen Gallerneaux)
3. Disorientation as a Learning Objective: Applying Transformational
Learning Theory in Participatory Action Pedagogy (Barbara Brown Wilson)
4. The Baye Faal of Senegambia: Muslim Rastas in the Promised Land?
(Neil J. Savishinsky)
5. Dumb Meaning: Machine Learning and Artificial Semantics (Hannes
Bajohr)
6. Language models can only write poetry (Allison Parrish)
7. TESCREAL hallucinations: Psychedelic and AI hype as inequality
engines (Neşe Devenot)

Hold me accountable!
```

I thought it was too soon to get back in Clarice Lispector after the rapture that was Agua Viva.



Last summer, I read Agua Viva alongside relistening and rereading parts of Malidoma Patrice Somé's Of Water and Spirit Ritual Magic and Initiation in the Life of an African Shaman (1995). Both texts made for an unnameable reading experience. The books simultaneously gave me language and took language away from me. Both texts were slippery. A duo of non-cohesion. Slippery as in:

slippery (adj.)

"having a surface so smooth as to cause sliding," c. 1500, *slipperie*, with **-y** (2) + Middle English *sliper* (adj.) "not affording firm footing or hold," from Old English *slipor* "slippery, having a smooth surface" (see **slip** (v.)).

The metaphoric sense of "deceitful, untrustworthy, that cannot be depended upon or trusted" is from 1550s. Alternative *slippy* is attested from 1540s. Related: *Slipperily; slipperiness*. Middle English also had *slipperness*, *slipornysse*, (early 15c., in medical writing, "looseness of the bowels"), directly from *sliper*. Scott (1821) has *slippiness*.

And I wondered if I would apply the last definition here – something that is deceitful. And yes, I would say that the form all these things had to take to be read and held in our hands presents a set of expectations that can never be fulfilled. Each time I returned to these texts, what I thought I read was no longer there, as if it had evaporated because they feared my attachment to the words and not the feeling I had while reading them. Reading these texts felt like a phantasmic experience.

phantasm (n.)

mid-13c., *fantesme*, "that which has only seeming reality, permanence, or value;" c. 1300 as "an illusory experience or object; an apparition;" from Old French *fantosme* "a dream, illusion, fantasy; apparition, ghost, phantom" (12c.), and directly from Latin *phantasma* "an apparition, specter," in Late Latin also "appearance, image," from Greek *phantasma* "image, phantom, apparition; mere image, unreality," from *phantazein* "to make visible, display," from stem of *phainein* "to bring to light, make appear; come to light, be seen, appear; explain, expound, inform against; appear to be so," from PIE root ***bha-** (1) "to shine." Spelling conformed to Latin from 16c. (see **ph**). A spelling variant of **phantom**, "differentiated, but so that the differences are elusive" [Fowler].

I found myself rereading and rereading these texts, trying to gain traction, something to grip onto. These texts resist attachment, or affinity, or binding. And I wondered if it was a resistance to the texts binding itself to me or a resistance to the human desire to grab the word, hold it tightly, and imprison it in the moment of our perception rather than allow its infinite blooming.

When I remembered this summer of reading, I was tempted recently, and cheated by reading something from The Complete Stories before first sneaking a peek at Helene Cixous' Reading Clarice Lispector:

> When we read a text, we are either read by the text or we are in the text. Either we tame a text, we ride on it, we roll over it, or we are swallowed up by it, as by a whale. There are thousands of possible relations to a text, and if we are in a nondefensive, nonresisting relationship, we are carried off by the text. This is mainly the way it goes. But then, in order to read, we need to get out of the text. We have to shuttle back and forth incessantly. We have to try all possible relations with a text. At some point, we have to disengage ourselves from the text as a living ensemble, in order to study its construction, its techniques, and its texture.

Ooooofff! To be inside a text. How do we name our relationship to a text? And that process of extrication to analyze the text feels the most excruciating. To climb out of an engorged sack. I want to stay in the text but to speak about the text, I cannot be in its belly. But, I love being in the belly of the text — it is warm, sloppy, and agitating. I read the first few pages of The Egg and the Chicken, (thank you to one of my students, Celine Nguyen for reminding me of this piece). Lispector writes:

> The egg is a suspended thing. It has never landed. When it lands, it is not what has landed. It was a thing under the egg. —I look at the egg in the kitchen with superficial attention so as not to break it. I take the utmost care not to understand it. Since it is impossible to understand, I know that if I understand it this is because I am making an error. Understanding is the proof of making an error. Understanding it is not the way to see it. —Never thinking about the egg is a way to have seen it. —I wonder, do I know of the egg? I almost certainly do. Thus: I exist, therefore I know. —What I don't know about the egg is what really matters. What I don't know about the egg gives me the egg properly speaking. —The Moon is inhabited by eggs.

Something about her writing makes it hard to read more than a few pages before needing a nap. See Helene Cixous' reminder:

> Clarice's texts, like Kafka's, are not narratives. They contain a secret, a lesson. But this secret and this lesson are dispersed in the verbal space in such a way that the meaning cannot be apprehended at a first reading. Discourse is that
> [...]
> able. It cannot be summarized. It is free. It diffuses and spreads. One of the texts closest to textuality is *Agua viva*. It is living water, water full of life. It cannot be

First, let's talk about eggs. Every few months, I am repulsed by eggs. I am in that cycle now. I can eat eggs cooked by someone else. However, I cannot crack the eggs, whip them, or cook them without gagging. This cyclical disgust reminds me that I refused to eat white and off-white foods up through the start of high school. Eggs, cottage cheese, yogurt, mayonnaise...all a no-no. The first time I tasted scrambled eggs, I remember the smell and felt like I was

eating something I was not supposed to eat. But, back to the eggs.

— "The egg is a suspended thing. It has never landed." The chalazae already allow the yolk to be suspended, so what might it mean for the egg to be a "suspended thing"? I am taking up the definition of suspended as the state of something being held undetermined or undecided, awaiting further information or a pause. I consider this suspension a possible articulation of an unresolved state that has not settled into a specific reality — something imminent. Or, as Helene Cixous writes:

> chicken, or there will be no more golden eggs. The text is a chicken that incessantly lays golden eggs. The text will not cease to lay golden eggs unless one makes an incision to go in and see what is in its belly. The meanings of a text are like the eggs: they are to come; they are in preparation. For an egg to be, one has

— "Understanding is the proof of making an error [...] What I don't know about the egg is what really matters. What I don't know about the egg gives me the egg properly speaking." To claim to understand is arrogance? A presumption of totality? Anytime we arrive at the shore of understanding, is it our own self-satisfying delusion? What we think we recognize and understand may be more a projection of a desire to capture than an actual capture.

```
Sidenote: Would folks join a Clarice Lispector reading group/class where
we slowly read her work and the paratext? I am thinking of something in
the winter to keep us warm with her language. And I am thinking of
something hybrid. If you'd be interested, send me an email
studio@kameelahr.com
```

ɔ Love is Curiosity(?)(!)

In a moment of the corporeal primitive hypertext Octavia Estelle Butler offers us, I was shuttled to another text. I moved my body to find a sister text of sorts and found myself back inside Elvia Wilk's essay, Ask Before You Bite (an updated version is included in her book Death By Landscape):

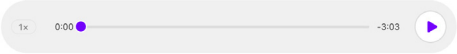
> Mutual love is often thought of as mutual recognition: I see you for who you are and you see me back. But recognition is inevitably also a naming, a fixing, a pinning down. In order to recognize, you have to categorize, and categories are notoriously inflexible. Recognition, if understood as a projection that disallows the evolution of self and identity, becomes restrictive rather than liberating. However inadvertently, the recognition required for mutual love can easily slip into a form of control.

Jan Verwoert describes the slippage between love-as-recognition and love-as-control in an essay called "Masters and Servants or Lovers: On Love as a Way to Not Recognize the Other." He writes,

> To love the other, we believe, is the most intimate way to recognize the other, to get to know and understand who he or she really is ... But this is what power is about as well, when it manifests itself in structures of domination. Modern regimes of power are built on the intimate knowledge of who the people are they dominate. Surveillance, espionage, and market research are techniques of recognition ... Consequently, radical love would be a love that goes beyond recognition, that is a love in which the lovers would renounce their desire to fully grasp the identity of the other and no longer insist on understanding who the other is.[1]

At least for Wilk, something about love implies a certain "knowing" or recognition of the other person. But as Wilk notes, "recognition is inevitably also a naming…Recognition, if understood as a projection that disallows the evolution of self…" Here, understanding is not so much an error as much as violence. This is hard for me to wrap my mind around because so much of our socialization is about the kindness of understanding others. But what if that has been an unfortunate trap and not a kindness? During one of my routine existential crises, I asked myself — do I desire for others to understand me, or do I desire for others to be curious about me? I landed on curiosity because understanding me would require stability that I cannot promise. As a learner, I pick up and put down so much each day that one might have to quantify a blur; there are no fixed points. Learning is moving stations in multiple directions — a series of blurs, but not fixed frames; the cut, not the frame.

When I think about my frustration in all forms of relationships, it has never been about someone being unable to understand me; it has been about their lack of curiosity about me—a feeling that whatever snapshot they'd taken was sufficient knowledge to be in relation to me.



I think love is curiosity.

I think love is an investment in quantum physics — or an awareness of all ambiguous scales of being down to the microscopic — a desire to hold space for persons as dark matter worth being curious about regardless of your ability to define it. (For more on dark matter, see Sarah Jane Cervenak's Black Gathering: Art, Ecology, Ungiven Life and Amy Catazano's work on Quantum Poetics). Catazano writes, "I often think of quantum mechanics as the most conceptually radical of the breakthroughs in theoretical physics to emerge in the last and current century, in part due to its claim that physical reality cannot be definitively observed." The reminder that ambiguity trumps certainty shapes my life and my new approach to relationships, first with myself and then with others.

My desire for curiosity over understanding was illuminated by something from Patricia Meyerowitz's translator introduction to Gertrude Stein's How to Write:

> It is useful to remember that the innovative works of an artist are explorations and therefore cannot easily be understood by those who are not explorers in one of the art forms. Nevertheless with a little effort it is possible to understand the direction and the intentions of the artist which is all that is necessary. Total comprehension would mean total involvement.

Another gut punch: "Total comprehension would mean total involvement." This sentence acknowledges the conditions for total comprehension, which are impossible.

ɔ Heresy and Curiosity

One more thing! I am thinking about my spiritual practice—one flowing in the direction of Sufism, which reminds me of the impossibility of understanding the divine, Allah, and, by extension, much else. I read something by Ashon Crawley that introduced me to apophatic theology, or negative theology — the opposite of cataphatic theology. (There is an X-Files episode that references this concept) Negative theology attempts to describe God by speaking only about what may not be said about the Divine. I am still disentangling all of this, but in this process, I learned about examples within Islam and was reintroduced to the concept of tanzih (as opposed to tashbih), or an assertion of the impossibility of comparison. I am not a scholar and am still learning, but it seems that much of this is rooted in a question of to what extent we can understand the Divine. When I think about what holds me within a particular tradition, it is the inability to know fully because to know fully gives me nothing more to work toward and wrestle with. I have nothing to be agitated by — an unanswered question, a point of disagreement — opportunities for curiosity.

My therapist used the word heretic today when I spoke about curiosity. And yes, curiosity is heretical; it can be blasphemous. I can imagine someone seeing my search history on these topics then concluding that I do not believe, but I believe so deeply that I want to explore all the contours. And to be quite frank, heterodoxy and heresy are necessary forces of agitation. Agitation, annoyance, and discordance are all modes of learning for me. Agitation is slightly erotic —

you are rubbed the wrong way, but you are still rubbed and the question becomes what does one make of that disruption.

The disruption is an awareness of oneself — to be able to identify a moment when something ruptures or upsets your membrane is to even acknowledge there is something that differentiates you from others. I enjoy agitation and annoyance — it is my pedagogical process; it is my spiritual practice. I enjoy the rupture of what I presumed to be a non-porous membrane. From Lispector's Agua Viva:

> To be born: I've watched a cat give birth. The kitten emerges wrapped in a sack of fluid and all huddled inside. The mother licks the sack of fluid so many times that it finally breaks and there a kitten almost free, only attached by its umbilical cord. Then the mother-creator-cat breaks that cord with her teeth and another fact appears in the world. That process is *it*. I am not joking. I am earnest. Because I am free. I am so simple.
>
> I am giving freedom to you. First I rip the sack of fluid. Then I cut the umbilical cord. And you are alive on your own account.

I am the mother that licks the sack of fluid. I am her. And I am the kitten huddled inside the sack. Who is licking the sack to free me? Must I free myself? There are no saviors, and Lucille Clifton reminds of of such:

> **the meeting after the savior gone**
> *4/4/68*
>
> what we decided is
> you save your own self.
> everybody so quiet.
> not so much sorry as
> resigned.
> we was going to try and save you but
> now i guess you got to save yourselves
> (even if you don't know
> who you are
> where you been
> where you headed
>
> ■

A short piece of writing during my train ride from Providence:

> The mystic dies and leaves behind engorged sentences. Violently, I stab the congested sacks of language, and with my mouth round and ready, I place myself at the site of puncture to see what I can catch on my tongue. It is not elegant and nothing like what I was told. Am I brave? No, just desperate to taste the letter; to chew a wad of lapsed meaning.

ɔ Heresy, Haunting, and Wet Sentences

Heresy and heterodoxy sit as haunts, as spectres, as reminders of uncertainty and the complete upsetting of everything we think we knew. I am thinking about Avery Gordon's renderings of haunting in Ghostly Matters: Haunting and the Sociological Imagination:

> We are asked, then, to consider two counterintuitive features of haunting. The first is that the ghost cannot be simply tracked back to an individual loss or trauma. The ghost has its own desires, so to speak, which figure the whole complicated sociality of a determining formation that seems inoperative (like slavery) or invisible (like racially gendered capitalism) but that is nonetheless alive and enforced. But the force of the ghost's desire is not just negative, not just the haunting and staged words, marks, or gestures of domination and injury. The ghost is not other or alterity as such, ever. It is (like Beloved) pregnant with unfulfilled possibility, with the something to be done that the wavering present is demanding. This something to be done is not a return to the past but a reckoning with its repression in the present, a reckoning with that which we have lost, but never had. The ghost always also figures

For me this is thrilling. Whether we acknowledge the haunt or not, there is always something waiting and available to unsettle our certainty.

ı *I have asked myself: "Can a sentence be haunted? And if so, by what?"*

So, how do we proceed? We write acknowledging that every sentence is haunted by the thing we do not yet know and may never come to know. We write wet, damp, and moist sentences. Something still liquid enough to be contaminated by new experiences, something liquid enough to change.

I write in the spirit of liquid, of water, or as Lispector says in Agua Viva

> ;, the water of an ever-trembling stream.

And over the past few weeks, I have found myself craving writing. Maybe it is that I am currently teaching a writing class at the School for Poetic Computation called Wayward Sentences. Whatever it is, I want to write. Yes, I still want to write about writing, but it is still writing. Sometimes, I wish I was a writer who enjoyed writing about "topics," but I love writing about the systems surrounding topics, the substrates that make the notion of topics even possible. It's like the natal cloud surrounding the star, not the star itself; or the paratext, not the text itself. I have felt a lot of insecurity about not having interests in this traditional way, but having never been good at fitting in, I will take this quirk as an invitation to carve out other ways to be part of writing communities.

Sometimes, I get so wrapped up in the poetics of a sentence's possible structure that I never finish the sentence. I enjoy thinking about, and thus writing about, ontology (what exists) and epistemology (how we can know about the existence of such a thing/how we know what we claim to know). Because writing is this technology to articulate these questions and claims, it makes sense that this becomes the heart of my interest in writing. There is also my dogged fascination with religion and hoaxes, both things that force me to confront why people believe what they believe and then why they stop believing certain things. When I think about my art practice, I call myself a learner because I see that my work is a series of epistemological gestures — what did I think I knew coming into this; what do I think I now know having created this work; how does the existence of this work impact how other people are reflecting on their knowing; how does the process of making and unmaking impact my relationship to knowledge; what are the lengths I am willing to go to know something (consider my show at REDCAT, i want to climb inside every word and lick the salty neck of each letter — a desire to know through erotic consumption).

Again, what lengths am I willing to go to to know something (or to think I do)?

כ i want to climb inside every word and lick the salty neck of each letter

For this REDCAT solo exhibition, I created 10 new video works. Four of these works were featured on CRT screens at the east of the gallery and all grouped under the title "...produces the pleasures of gastroscopy and of language"* (*Title comes from Roland Barthes, The Pleasures of the Text).

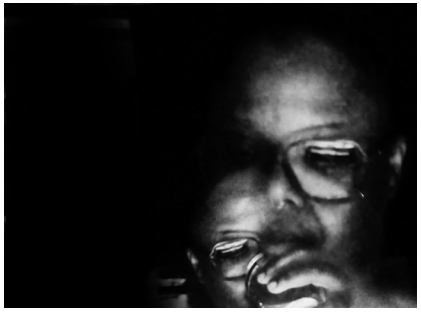
As I wrote:

> Since witnessing communion for the first time in Catholic school, I have been interested in consumption—based spiritual rituals. More formally since 2021, I have actively researched a number of spiritual rituals involving gastroscopy: kombe, the ingestion of liquified Qur'anic verses; the Holy Communion sacrament; Schluckbildchen, devotional pictures created for swallowing in German folk medicine; and baau, a Peruvian Urarina practice of whispering healing words into liquid to be drunk by the afflicted. Here, intimacy is corporeal and immersive — to read and to write is to consume and absorb — to transgress. Four videos mirror the escalation of physical contact and intimacy - from touch to consumption. Below each is a small shelf holding residue from the gastroscopic rituals captured on screen: a square of paper I have rubbed my body up against; a strip of paper I have licked; a glass jar holding the remainder of the sentence dissolved in water that I drank; and the watery remnants of the paper patty I created and consumed.

Rubbing the Word: "For I want to feel in my hands the quivering and lively nerve of the now..."*(*Title comes from Clarice Lispetor, Agua Viva), 2024, 1:52 min

Licking the Word: "The mother licks the sack of fluid so many times that it finally breaks..."*(*Title comes from Clarice Lispetor, Agua Viva), 2024, 1:48 min

Drinking the Word: “Like a priest gulping down his Mass”*(*Title comes from Roland Barthes, The Pleasures of the Text), 2024, 2:47 min



Eating the Word: “We are gorged with language…”*(*Title comes from Roland Barthes, The Pleasures of the Text), 2024, 1:40 min

I have not talked about the physical toll of this work. More on that soon.

Thank you for reading,

Kameelah 👽

Rasheed, K. (2024, October 26). [27 May 2024]: ''Using the Word as Bait'' — blind bisexual goose; green porno; slippery texts; sloshy belly of texts; eggs; love as curiosity + quantum mechanics; heresy + agitation; erotic consumption. I Will (?) Figure This All Out Later. https://newsletter.kameelahr.com/p/27-may-2024-using-the-word-as-bait

This reader was printed on the occasion of the *...have ...word* reading group
organized by rile* between October 6th and December 15th 2024 in Brussels.

...have ...word reading group

```rile* books

October — December 2024
```